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1 is Epistemology?
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Doing Epistemology

1.1 A parable, or two

What is epistemology? It is ... no, wait a moment. Let us start more slowly and reflectively, with an analogy.

Have you heard the parable of the blind men and the elephant? These men encounter their first elephant. 'What is this?' 'It's an elephant, I was told.' 'What is *that*?' One man – touching the trunk – answers that an elephant is like a snake. Another grasps an ear: 'An elephant is like a fan.' A third man feels the animal's side: 'No, an elephant is like a wall.' And so on. Each man touches a distinct part of the animal, deriving a view of the whole on the basis of that part – with each being mistaken about that whole. None of the men experiences enough of the elephant to know its general nature. But none of them thinks of himself as being too limited in that way. Each pronounces confidently – although ignorantly – upon the nature of elephants, by applying some evidence; not *enough* evidence, though.

We can adapt that parable. We can apply it to people puzzled about the nature of knowledge (rather than of elephants). We should do this because *epistemology*

typically begins by reaching out and asking – puzzled – about knowledge's nature, as those blind men pondered the nature of elephants. How do we ensure that we will not fail as those men did? *Can* we understand knowledge's nature? Or – like the blind men – are we too restricted to do so? Must we remain ignorant, without realizing it, about what knowledge is?

Imagine asking different people, 'What is knowledge?' This is not the same question as 'What is *known*?' In epistemology, our aim is not to compile a list of instances of knowledge – what you know, what your mother knows, etc. Such a list could include useful data, as we seek to understand what knowledge is. But it is not our ultimate goal. Instead, we want to push our thinking beyond any such list. We wish to discover what *makes* anything on that list an instance of knowledge: *why* is your knowledge knowledge? What makes *anyone's* knowledge knowledge? Thinking about only your knowledge, say, is like touching simply the elephant's tail. Thinking just about your mother's knowledge is like touching merely the elephant's tusk. We need to think far more widely about knowledge.

How much more widely, though? Knowing knowledge's nature is like knowing the nature of elephants. You need to observe or think about *enough* instances and aspects of knowledge, if you are to understand knowledge's nature, just as scientists need to observe or think about *enough* instances and aspects of elephants, if they are to uncover the general nature of elephants.

People usually assume that they use the term 'know' accurately because they already understand what knowledge is. But might that optimism be mistaken? Centuries of philosophical thought have discovered subtlety and complexity in the term 'know' (and its variants). Is everyone *aware* of that history, that subtlety and complexity? Imagine asking 'What is knowledge?' to people from different professions – educated people

who are paid well to apply knowledge appropriate to their profession. Their answers could vary dramatically – so that not all of them could be correct – much as the blind men's answers did. A business-person might claim that all real knowledge ('worthy of the name') can be 'monetized' – usable in ways that bring financial success. A theoretical physicist might expect that all knowledge ('worthy of the name') encodes a numerical reality, regardless of whether money can be made from that knowledge. An experimental physicist might regard as real knowledge ('worthy of the name') only what can be verified by observations, including in controlled experiments. A sociologist might insist that all knowledge ('worthy of the name') is whatever is socially believed. And so on. Each professional gives voice to a conception of knowledge used within her field. Equally, though, maybe none of those professionals takes into account how the others – within *their* fields – think about knowledge's nature. Potentially, we have another version of the blind-men-and-the-elephant parable. Maybe each professional notices only part of the story, just an aspect of what knowledge is. Each might be wrong – too limited in their thinking – about knowledge in *general*.

That is more significant for them than they might realize. If you do not understand what knowledge in general is, you do not understand what knowledge is *at all*. Just as the blind men were wrong about what *even one* elephant is, each of our professionals might be wrong about what *even one* instance of knowledge is. That is, they could be wrong about what they assume is their *own* kind of knowledge, given their lack of understanding of knowledge in general. And none of them will notice this failing, just as each blind man was oblivious to his own failing.

This is where epistemology enters. It asks about knowledge in general – everyone's knowledge, all knowledge, at any time, in any place. It aims to reveal the

nature of something – knowledge-possession – that could well unite us with people from all cultures and all centuries. *What* you know differs from what ancient Chinese or Greek people knew. Yet was their knowledge *the same general kind* of thing as yours? Knowledge seems to be something that people have long gained, especially as humanity has developed over the millennia. But can we be more detailed and insightful about *what* knowledge is?

With that question, we take a first step towards being epistemological.

1.2 Epistemology as philosophy

Further steps are then needed. After asking ‘What is knowledge?’, what should we do next? Well, epistemology is part of *philosophy*. Its methods and aims are philosophical. It seeks to understand knowledge *in a philosophical way*. But what does this mean? What is a philosophical understanding?

Here is a suggestion.

When someone claims to have a philosophy, for her it is a *template* and a *tool*. She uses it to regard, interpret, and react to the world – hoping to understand the world in a special way. What does ‘special’ mean here? Her philosophy is a *lens* through which she views the world, perhaps explaining to herself what she sees and experiences. Her philosophy can be a *manual* to guide her actions. She might be able to use it, often and widely: no matter what challenges she meets in life, she might hope that her philosophy will supply answers. It can also give her confidence about how best to describe and respond to the world.

Now, if that is the basic idea of a philosophy at all, many people should claim to have a philosophy. Many embrace a religion; and religions are often held in that same spirit, amounting to philosophies. If a philosophy

is an *interpretive and motivating model* – helping one to regard and react to the world – then a religion can be a philosophy. Of course, not only religions are like that. An epistemology is a philosophy by being an interpretive and motivating model: it allows one to decide when knowledge is present, perhaps how to gain and act with knowledge. A religion can also be a philosophy by being an interpretive and motivating model, such as of the world’s creation and of what it is to live morally well.

It seems, then, that there are many philosophies. But are all of them equally worthy, powerful, or insightful? Possibly not. One way for a philosophy to be better as a philosophy is for it to be a more *fundamental* picture of the world. There are at least the following two elements in this fundamentality.

First, a philosophy of X should portray X’s fundamental *nature*. Religions often aspire to that, as do the epistemological theories that you will meet in this book. A religion wants to distinguish properly between whatever is sacred, say, and whatever is not – as part of understanding *what it is* to be sacred. An epistemology wants to distinguish properly between whatever is knowledge, say, and whatever is not – as part of understanding *what it is* to be knowledge. (The blind men needed – but failed – to distinguish properly between elephants and non-elephants, in trying to understand *what it is* to be an elephant.)

Second, a philosophy can portray a more, or a less, fundamental kind of *thing*, relative to reality as a whole. A religion, as a philosophy of the sacred, is a more fundamental philosophy of the ultimate nature of reality, say, than a philosophy of partying would be. The same is true of an epistemology, as a philosophy of knowledge. Parties can be fun. Presumably, though, the sacred and knowledge are more fundamental to reality – more ultimately definitional of reality and its potential – than parties are.

Still, *how* fundamental can an epistemology be? *How* deeply must we delve, into the world and ourselves, if we are to understand what it is to know?

1.3 Being epistemological

This book will try to help you to answer that question. First, though, here is a useful distinction: *having* a philosophy of X is not the same as *being philosophical* about X. The latter is active; the former need not be. One might possess a philosophy of X without doing anything philosophical with it. It is one thing to *have* an epistemology (a philosophy of X, for 'X' = 'knowledge'); it is another thing to *be* epistemological, even for a moment. And this book is mainly about being epistemological. It aims to be doing epistemology. It aims to encourage you to do epistemology.

A related distinction is between *an epistemology* and *being epistemological*. One can *be* epistemological with *an* epistemology. But this is not guaranteed: one could *have* an epistemology without *being* epistemological with it. An epistemology is a collection of theses or beliefs (like any other philosophy). Imagine someone, Rasa, waking from a long slumber, never having thought about philosophy, yet now having an epistemology in mind. The epistemology is Just There – suddenly, with no warning – in her mind. So, Rasa now *has* an epistemology. She writes it down, as its claims float through her consciousness. A friend says, 'That's an epistemology! From where did it come?' Rasa has no answer. She stares at those sentences, perplexed. How is she to use this epistemology, now present within her? Is it, for her, a useless bunch of thoughts, jostling pointlessly within her mind (no matter that they are epistemological in themselves, in their content)?

Actually, she could do much with those thoughts – not all of which amounts to being epistemological,

though. Rasa might stand on a street corner, shouting her newly acquired epistemology at strangers; she might write its claims on pieces of paper, stick these on her bedroom walls, and repeat the claims to herself each morning, telling herself to believe them; etc. But none of this would be an epistemological *use* of these ideas. Yes, Rasa now possesses an epistemology, in a minimal way – as one can hold in one's hand a philosophy book, newly purchased. Yet one might never read and apply that philosophy book within one's life. Rasa possesses her epistemology like that, in literally a useless way. She does not own it in a way that will lead to her *being* epistemological in how she behaves: she will never *do* any epistemology with it.

What *would* be an epistemological way to act? Imagine being in a situation like Rasa's. For example, your philosophy teacher tells you to write down a bunch of sentences, telling you that these are from epistemology. How can you react epistemologically? How can you now be epistemological with those sentences?

You might begin by asking yourself whether they are true. Take the time to examine them critically – refining, testing, discarding, extending, replacing, etc. This might place in your mind a polished epistemology, one that 'feels true'. Is this all that is needed? For that moment, perhaps so. But if you then proceed to repeat the sentences mindlessly when asked about them (perhaps you believe them to be true), no longer are you being actively epistemological with them! So, continuing to be epistemological – even with that polished epistemology (those sentences, those claims) – is more than this. It includes remaining open actively to *continuing* to ask whether the philosophy in one's mind or hand is true: 'Although I think that it is true, might it be false? Are there good reasons to discard it, reasons that I have overlooked so far, reasons to replace it with a better philosophy?' Thinking like that is how one *lives* in being philosophical. So, in being actively epistemological, one

is developing and examining ideas about knowledge, wondering genuinely whether the ideas (even while seeming true) might be false. (A perfect God, I take it, could have an epistemology. Presumably, this would be an ultimate epistemology, wholly true and complete. But surely God would never be *doing* epistemology, in the sense described here. God would never need to wonder whether His epistemology is true. He would not be like us in this respect, I assume.)

So, being epistemological can be intellectually demanding (because being philosophical can be like that). It can also be emotionally demanding. Courage might be needed: many people are scared to question a 'big' philosophy, let alone to discard one. I said that a religion can be a philosophy. To be religious, though, is not necessarily to be philosophical. If one is to be philosophical with one's religion, then one must be *genuinely questioning* it. This can be emotionally confronting, since one is raising a real possibility of losing one's religion.

It can likewise be emotionally confronting to question one's epistemology. 'Maybe I've been living with what I thought was knowledge – but really is not! Have I been so deluded about myself?' To take seriously this possibility – not treating it as a mere intellectual curiosity – is potentially unsettling. *Really* to wonder whether one has been so self-deluded? *Really* to wonder how to think and study, if one is to gain knowledge? *Really* to wonder how to evaluate one's cognitive, intellectual, professional, or educative efforts?

Certainly it is easy *not* to confront oneself in that way. It is easy to close one's mind to such awkward possibilities. Imagine being presented with an epistemology, perhaps in an engrossing book. The epistemology might include claims about knowledge's nature. What if you simply accept those claims, never really questioning their being true? You might then use the book as a manual, to decide whether various beliefs

or opinions – yours or other people's – are knowledge. Time after time, you will say or think, 'Yes/no. My/your belief does/doesn't fit my conception of knowledge. So, it is/isn't knowledge.' You do this repeatedly, always brandishing the book, never refining or doubting its conception of knowledge. Is this how you want to be? You would be like someone who continually decides, in virtue of holding a 'fixed' conception of morality, whether various actions are morally good – without ever seriously wondering and questioning whether that conception of moral goodness is correct. Although that person *has* in mind a moral philosophy, she is not *being* philosophical with it. She is using her philosophy *dogmatically* – which is not a truly philosophical way to use it. She is never really *wondering whether* it is the right tool for the job of deciding which views are knowledge.

All of this gives us a simple moral: active questioning is needed for being epistemological, and then for staying epistemological. Of course, I am not advising anyone to become relentlessly epistemological by pondering knowledge's nature at every moment. But there are times to adopt an epistemological way of being. For instance, reflecting on knowledge's nature might alert you (as Chapter 3 will do) to the role of *good evidence* in having knowledge. This can make you better at using evidence, hence at gaining knowledge.

1.4 What epistemology is not

We have noted some features that epistemology shares with religion – but also how being epistemological seems to clash with being religious.

Or could we blend these two ways of being, in a religious epistemology? A simple first attempt to do so might give us this: 'Something is knowledge just in virtue of *God's deeming it* to be knowledge.' This is epistemological in its content, since it is about knowledge's

fundamental nature. Yet one is not being epistemological in proposing this view about knowledge, unless one is genuinely prepared to examine, in an open-minded way, whether the claim is true in its linking of knowing and God. By all means, defend the claim as true. But if your defence is to be epistemological, you must really be inquiring into whether the claim is true. You must not merely be defending it against objections without really listening for whatever merit those objections might have. So, details of attitude and action matter for whether epistemology is actually being done.

It is easy to confuse epistemology with other areas of thought. For instance, epistemology is not a form of sociology. Imagine having a sociological description of some society as including widespread acceptance of various beliefs. These beliefs might play historically valued roles for those people. Still, this does not tell us whether those beliefs are knowledge: even a socially valued belief might not be knowledge. (And *calling* such beliefs 'knowledges' – as sometimes occurs in sociological discussions – reveals nothing constructive about knowledge's nature.) It is a further epistemological question whether that culturally significant pedigree makes a belief knowledge. Epistemologists ask whether the belief is likely to be *true*, or whether it is supported by genuinely good *evidence*. People's having a belief, even holding it passionately, need not make it true, or well supported by evidence, let alone knowledge: a group of people can be mistaken or irrational. Even a belief's having *long* been socially valued by many people does not guarantee its being knowledge: mistakes and irrationality can linger.

What of epistemology's relation to psychology? Suppose that we have a scientific description of how people, with their inherent cognitive structuring, tend to reason in forming some kinds of belief. The epistemological question then arises of whether people *should* reason in those ways, if knowledge is the aim. Some

epistemologists consult psychological evidence about how people in general reason, in thinking about whether the beliefs being formed are knowledge: 'Are the beliefs being reached via *good* reasoning?' But is psychology the final word here? It has this possible advantage over sociology: maybe it uncovers 'hard-wired' facts about us, while sociology describes comparatively arbitrary aspects of how people form beliefs. Even psychology, however, might not be enough to tell us what it takes for reasoning to be *good* – that is, good enough to be producing knowledge.

1.5 Looking behind appearances

Suppose that being epistemological includes inquiring in a way that involves questioning, as it tries to decide between competing ideas about knowing's fundamental nature. How far should this questioning take us? Here we may reach for another important distinction, between what philosophers call *the manifest image* and *the scientific image*.

You have a choice as to how to be looking at the world. First, you can view it in an 'everyday' way – settling for the *manifest* image. You might think about the world in everyday terms, describing it in ways available to anyone, including people who have not learnt much science. Or, second, you could be seeing the world more as science does. You might describe the world by using scientific concepts and principles. Science lets you 'step behind' everyday appearances. Science lets you 'look behind' the manifest image, seeing something more fundamental, something deeper about reality. Science opens the door to the *scientific* image of the world.

Yet not all of our important thinking is either completely everyday or wholly scientific. There are 'in-between' options. For example, images that are less deep and powerful – but that are still *like* scientific

insights into reality – are provided by plumbers, electricians, etc., when they reveal inner structural details of how houses are built and maintained. Otherwise, one would be limited to gazing upon a house in an everyday way, perhaps seeing it simply as strong, solid, sleek. That would be the house's *manifest* image. In contrast, what we can call an *artisan's* image of the house (extending the idea of a *scientific* image) can reveal something more vulnerable, more fragile, with lots of potential – hidden from the less informed gaze of a prospective purchaser – for problems to arise within the house's inner or deeper aspects. The artisan's image understands better the house's underlying reality, and its fundamental details, than are revealed by the manifest image of the house (the mere *dweller's* image?).

That sort of added insight is also akin to what we gain through what could be called *the philosophical image* – including *the epistemological image*. People talk casually of what seems to be knowledge, of who knows what. Is it really knowledge, though? Even if various claims or beliefs look like knowledge when viewed in everyday ways or settings – within a *manifest* (non-philosophical) image of the world of knowing – maybe a longer and more searching perusal behind that appearance reveals something more complicated, even something quite different. This deeper look behind that appearance is what we gain by doing epistemology, seeking an *epistemological* image of the world of knowing.

The result could be like a kind of experience that I have been having recently in Sydney. Many buses these days have large advertisements on their exterior, spread across the windows (able to be removed, new ones taking their place). From outside the bus, one sees a glamorously portrayed Hollywood actor, for instance. From inside the bus, one gazes through those same windows – experiencing the passing world, in not quite a normal way, through what is actually a mosaic of tiny

holes, noticeable with a shift of attention, separated from each other with a pattern of lines. This is the inner reality, as it were, of what has been attached to the bus – but of what, when viewed from outside, looks like the Hollywood actor. From outside, one sees the apparent reality as it is designed to be seen: a glamorous picture. From inside, one sees the same reality differently. One sees it from behind, noticing how the outer effect is created. Well, doing epistemology – forming an epistemological image – is like entering the bus, remembering how it looks from outside, while now seeing it from inside – yet also now understanding how that outside appearance is created. Doing epistemology is complex. Welcome aboard!

1.6 This book (and a hint of history)

The term 'epistemology' did not enter the English language until the nineteenth century. But epistemological thinking is much older than that. The term 'epistemology' comes from the ancient Greek word '*epistēmē*', usually translated as 'knowledge'. So, epistemology is the 'ology' of knowledge, the 'theory' of knowledge. It is 'knowledgeology' (to introduce an ungainly term!), and hence epistemologists are 'knowledgeologists'! The first written epistemological thinking within Western philosophy comes from Plato, around the fourth century BCE in Athens, mainly in his *Meno* and his *Theaetetus*. Plato gave Western philosophy so much, not only epistemology. (What an amazing time and place to have lived! Socrates taught Plato, who then taught Aristotle. These are among the greatest philosophers ever.) Along with much else within philosophy, epistemology was under way.

Between then and now, epistemology's role within philosophy has shifted shape and location a number of times. It has always been there, in one form or another.

At times, it has been the most prominent and respected part of philosophy; at other times, it has played a supporting role, standing patiently in the background. In some centuries, its emphasis has been on describing *ways and kinds* of knowing. There have been periods when *doubts* about knowing have dominated, feeling like serious threats to our ever having knowledge. And, of course, what *is* knowledge in the first place? This question was posed by Plato, and has been vigorously debated in recent decades: can we definitively define *what knowledge really is*?

This book will discuss all of those main strands within the evolving history that has constituted epistemology over the past 2,500 years. (To be epistemological is thus to reflect, in a genuinely inquiring and philosophical way, on at least some of those strands.) Chapter 2 is on *ways and kinds* of knowing. Chapters 3 and 4 are on *what knowledge really is*. Chapter 5 is on *doubts* about knowing. Chapter 6 will gesture at how we might usefully – and provocatively – apply some of those questions and ideas within our lives.

2

Kinds of Knowledge

2.1 Data, please

Chapter 1 encouraged us to understand what it really is to have some knowledge. Chapter 3 will engage fully with that challenge. Before we can do so, though, we need *data* – knowledge-data. We also need to *organize* those data if we are to find a good theory (of knowledge's nature) with which to interpret them. All of that is this chapter's role: to gather knowledge-data; to start organizing the data; to notice whatever epistemological themes emerge.

This approach to inquiry should seem familiar. Before anyone could have understood what it is to be an elephant, for example, good elephant-data were needed. Over here: this is an elephant. Over there: it looks like ... yes, another elephant. Notice any shared features that might matter for classifying and understanding these animals. Observe the animals' behaviour – what they do, where and how they do it. Will this reveal why they act as they do? And look further afield, for a wide range of individuals. Down